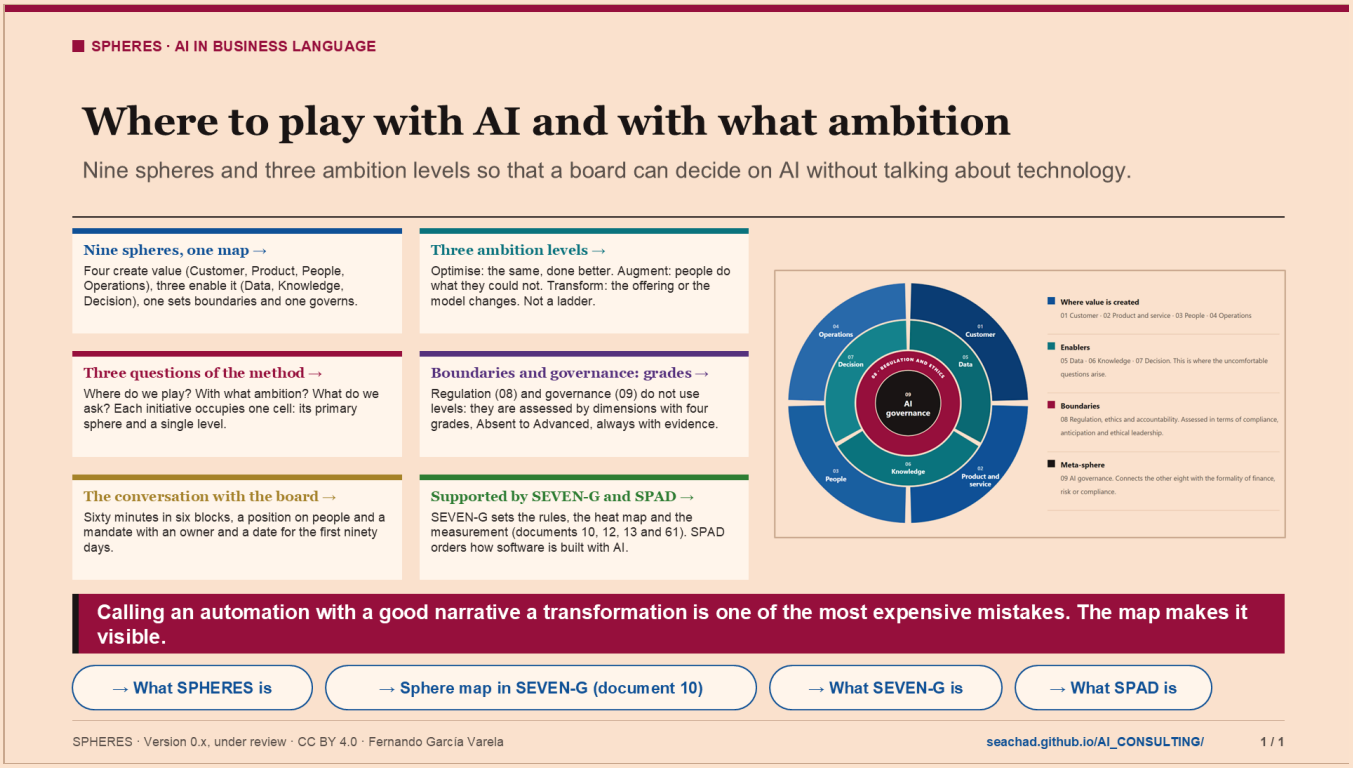


Notes

SPHERES organises everything that artificial intelligence can change in a company into nine spheres and grades each bet with three ambition levels. Its purpose is to let a board talk about AI in business language: where to play, with what ambition and what to ask. The name is not an acronym: it is the English word spheres.

The nine spheres are read from the outside in, in four types:

- Where value is created: 01 Customer, 02 Product and service, 03 People and 04 Operations. They are the only ones with direct value: revenue, retention, margin, productivity, cost or quality.
- Enablers: 05 Data, 06 Knowledge and 07 Decision. They do not generate value in themselves, but they constrain it. A Transform ambition in Customer without reliable data is a sign of risk, not of boldness.
- Boundaries: 08 Regulation, ethics and accountability.
- Meta-sphere: 09 AI governance, which connects the other eight.

The three levels describe what changes in the business, not the technology used. Optimise means doing the same thing faster, more cheaply or with fewer errors; for example, classifying the enquiries that reach customer service. Augment means that people do what they could not do before; for example, a copilot that enables analysts to review transactions that they previously referred to specialists. Transform means changing what is offered, how the company competes or how it is organised; for example, a machinery manufacturer that starts selling guaranteed operating hours thanks to predictive maintenance. They are not a ladder: Transform is not better than Optimise. Investment, uncertainty and resistance increase from one level to the next; that is why each level is decided and measured with different criteria. To classify an initiative there are five questions, answered with evidence. In case of doubt, the lower level is assigned.

The three questions of the method are: where do we play? (the sphere map), with what ambition? (the levels) and what do we ask? (questions, warning signs and a script for each sphere). Each initiative occupies one cell of the map: its primary sphere, which is the sphere of the metric that justifies the investment, and a single

level. The map is read at three points in time (current situation, target ambition and portfolio) and almost always shows concentration, gaps and incoherences. Fictitious example: a distribution company with twenty initiatives finds that nineteen are Optimise, that Product and service is empty and that nobody is accountable for AI. It is becoming more efficient, not transforming. The board takes five decisions without needing technical knowledge.

Spheres 08 and 09 do not use ambition levels, because they do not generate value in themselves. Each has three dimensions (08: Compliance, Anticipation and Ethical leadership; 09: Structure, Balance between speed and control and Supplier ecosystem) that are assessed with four grades: Absent, Basic, Systematic and Advanced. A grade is assigned with evidence, not with an optimistic self-assessment.

The conversation with the board follows a sixty-minute script in six blocks: framing, value spheres, enablers, regulation, position on people (whether AI replaces, augments or reorganises work) and governance. It ends with a mandate for ninety days: diagnosis, risks and opportunities by sphere, and governance structure.

SPHERES is component A (impact map) of SEVEN-G. SPHERES explains; SEVEN-G sets the rules. SEVEN-G document 10 sets the sphere and level rules, the indicators with a formula and the heat map (T16); document 12, the five questions and the transformation index; document 13, the target ambition by sphere; and document 61, the full script for the board. The initiative register (T01) records the sphere and level of each initiative, and the board AI dashboard (T17) shows the heat map. SPAD (Structured Prompt-Driven Engineering) is an independent methodology: it governs how software is built with AI, with blocking phases and independent review. Its verdicts do not replace the SEVEN-G decision gates.

Why it matters: without a common language, each area talks about AI in its own way. With the same map, the board compares bets, detects gaps and decides where to invest.

Question for the classroom: place three AI initiatives of a company you know on the map. Which one is presented as a transformation and is, in fact, Optimise?

SOURCES AND LINKS

- **SPHERES 00 · What SPHERES is and what it is for** https://seachad.github.io/AI_CONSULTING/SPHERES/html/en/00_SPHERES_Que_es_y_para_que_sirve.html
- **SPHERES 01 · Ambition levels: how to classify an initiative** https://seachad.github.io/AI_CONSULTING/SPHERES/html/en/01_SPHERES_Niveles_de_ambicion.html#how-to-classify-an-initiative
- **SPHERES 05 · Conversation with the board: sixty-minute script** https://seachad.github.io/AI_CONSULTING/SPHERES/html/en/05_SPHERES_Conversacion_con_el_consejo.html#sixty-minute-script
- **SEVEN-G 10 · Sphere-level heat map (T16)** https://seachad.github.io/AI_CONSULTING/SEVEN-G/html/en/10_SEVEN-G_Mapa_de_esferas_y_niveles_de_ambicion.html#sphere-level-heat-map-t16
- **SEVEN-G 13 · AI thesis, ambition and risk appetite** https://seachad.github.io/AI_CONSULTING/SEVEN-G/html/en/13_SEVEN-G_Tesis_de_IA_ambicion_y_apetito_de_riesgo.html
- **SPAD 00 · Relationship with SEVEN-G** https://seachad.github.io/AI_CONSULTING/SPAD/html/en/00_SPAD_Que_es_y_para_que_sirve.html#relationship-with-seven-g
- **What SPHERES is** https://seachad.github.io/AI_CONSULTING/SPHERES/html/en/00_SPHERES_Que_es_y_para_que_sirve.html
- **Sphere map in SEVEN-G (document 10)** https://seachad.github.io/AI_CONSULTING/SEVEN-G/html/en/10_SEVEN-G_Mapa_de_esferas_y_niveles_de_ambicion.html
- **What SEVEN-G is** https://seachad.github.io/AI_CONSULTING/SEVEN-G/html/en/entrada/index.html
- **What SPAD is** https://seachad.github.io/AI_CONSULTING/SPAD/html/en/00_SPAD_Que_es_y_para_que_sirve.html

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